

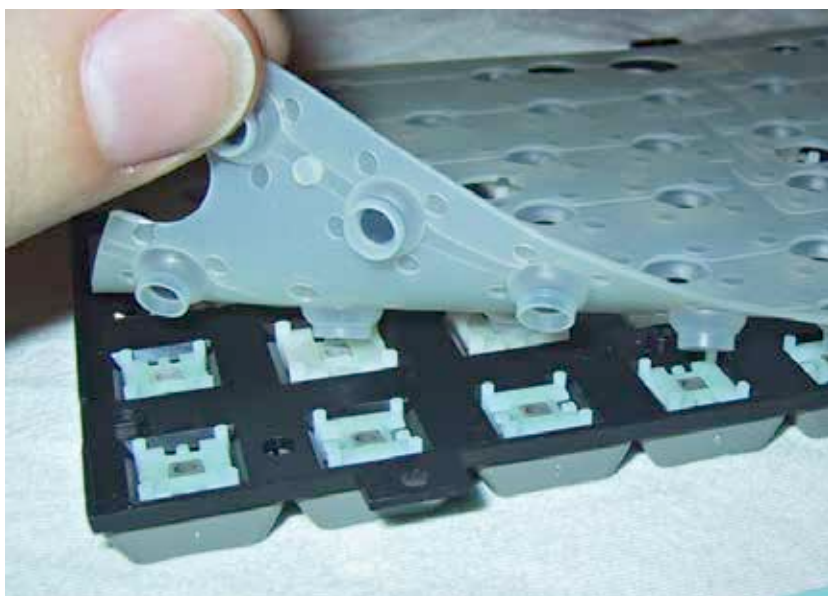
could last for four hours honey!", you complain, like a new arranged-marriage bride... As you play out your soap opera in the park, we zoom out of the scene to see you in a tiny park surrounded by traffic jams, and the smog acts as a natural fade out into black. A narrator (preferably in the voice of Morgan Freeman) booms "Battery claims are as honest as a used car salesman, or a lawyer!"

If we could make a public service ad about laptop batteries, that might be it. Why? Because the claimed battery life of laptops is now so far removed from reality, that it's worth at least four turds. The only reason it doesn't get the fifth, is because at some specific setting with nothing installed and all services turned off and CPU running in lowest power mode, etc., you can actually get close to the claimed figure. Of course your laptop essentially becomes a paperweight at those settings, but it is theoretically possible. Laptops that don't have user-removable batteries (because of super slim designs and whatnot) maybe deserve five turds, because it's not like you can buy a higher capacity battery like before, and end up having to visit a service centre for an expensive battery replacement.

NOISELESS KEYBOARDS



Three turds for whoever came up with the idea of marketing cheaper membrane keyboards this way. The "silent typing experience", "noiseless keystroke reaction", "comfortable", "silent switch tactile feeling", etc., claims you will see are essentially marketing you poo as "the heady fragrance of Mumbai's railway tracks". Yes, membrane keyboards are "silent" compared to some mechanical keyboards, but they're also pretty useless. The average membrane keyboard is rated at 8 to 10 million keystrokes, while their mechanical counterparts start at 30 and go all the way up to 70 million keystrokes. Some membrane keyboards can barely manage 5 million. That said, read this month's Boo-man column, because as it turns out, even mechanical switches seem to be heading in the direction where they need to be awarded turds.



Membrane switches on the top, mechanical switches on the bottom.

MEMMECHANICAL KEYBOARDS



Yup, that is not a typo. Mechanical keyboards have actual spring-based switches below the keys, while membrane keyboards have a rubber dome beneath the keys to simulate the resistance of a switch. Then there are memmechanical keyboards – half-mechanical keyboards, where the switch is still membrane, but a mechanical plate is added above the switch to make a clicking sound. Paying premium for this is a strict no-no, because they're just as crap as the average membrane keyboards, and in fact, the experience can be a little funny, as the click that occurs when you lift your finger is heard before the key itself rises!

HIGH DPI MICE



DPI stands for dots per inch. On mice it is a measure of how much the cursor moves on screen compared to how much the mouse moves on the pad. There are some mice in the market that offer insanely high DPI settings, over 10,000 or so. There is absolutely no need for this, even when gaming. If you set your Windows mouse tracking speed to the lowest possible setting, you still can't raise the mouse DPI to more than 6,000, because it becomes unusable. So who exactly needs 10,000 or 12,000 DPI we have no idea. Even if you have an insanely large monitor, you'd still want some control over your mouse, right?